Russian President Vladimir Putin's long-delayed summit with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, his first in four years, unfolds at a moment when US president Donald Trump is violently rearranging the global chessboard. A time when the world is sharply polarised by war, sanctions and shifting power centres, forcing nations to rethink old assumptions and quietly redraw their strategic maps. In this charged backdrop, Putin's India visit is far more than a routine bilateral; it is a signal, to the West and to the Global South, about where Moscow believes its long-term partners lie and for India to tell the US that it cannot be bullied into submission. Both sides look to reboot their relationship.

In a rare and exclusive interview to the India Today Group's TV team of **Anjana Om Kashyap and Geeta Mohan** at the Kremlin on the eve of his visit, Putin spoke for 100 minutes on a wide range of issues that went beyond India-Russia relations. The Russian president was by turns combative, didactic and unexpectedly warm, especially when speaking of India and Modi, whom he calls his "friend" and whose setting of "challenging tasks" for the nation he praises. For Putin, New Delhi is not just a legacy ally, but a central player in what he describes as the emerging power centres of the Global South: BRICS, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, and a looser coalition of Asian and African economies that are reshaping trade, finance and technology.

On India–Russia relations, he says the future lies not just in defence, but as much in high-technology cooperation in nuclear energy, space, shipbuilding, aviation and, crucially, artificial intelligence. That's besides an ambitious agenda to correct trade imbalances, and not by diktat. Putin criticises western attempts to pressure India over discounted Russian oil and sanctions, arguing that some actors "dislike India's growing role in international markets" and are using political tools to distort fair competition.

Asked about the Ukraine war, Putin cast the conflict as a defence of Russian-speaking populations, traditional values, language and the Orthodox Church. The "special military operation", he told the India Today TV team, is not the start of a war, but an attempt to end one started "at the hands of Ukrainian nationalists aided by the West", and which will conclude only once Russia meets its goals of "liberating territories" and strengthening its security. NATO expansion, in his telling, remains the central strategic grievance.

The interview is also a rare insight into how Putin reads Trump's return and the West. He is dismissive of rejoining the G8, sceptical of the continued centrality of the G7, and more interested in alternative platforms where India and China sit at the high table. On India–China tensions, Putin treads a careful line. He calls both countries Russia's "closest friends", says he has no right to interfere, but stresses that Modi and Xi Jinping are applying "maximum effort" to manage disputes and that their "wisdom" is ensuring that tensions do not derail a broader Asian rebalancing.

Throughout the interaction, Putin appeared in full command, with a swag in the manner that he walked and spoke. He was extremely gracious and charming too. Despite being quizzed for over an hour and a half, he agreed to an informal discussion with the India Today Group Editorial Team and answer their questions. Edited excerpts of the interview: